Bora, who is already in Jharkhand lending her voice to the protests against alleged irregularities in the state PSC and Staff Selection Commission exams, says the government's response of passing a paper leak law focuses more on punishment than on fixing the system. "If you want to stop paper leaks, then an agency like the NTA (National Testing Agency), which functions in a completely opaque manner, has to be either scrapped or made a statutory body where its accountability is fixed."

These are views that Ranka, too, shares. "You are discussing everything that happens after a paper leak...fast-track courts, stricter punishment, penalties. But you still haven't said what you are doing to stop it."

CAUSE AND EFFECT

The first-ever 'Cockroach Conclave' also marks the moment when it confronts a structural dilemma: can it sustain itself? For pollster Yashwant Deshmukh, that question is bigger than the CJP itself. "In every decade, during every movement, there was always a leader, a face around whom people would rally," he says, citing Jayaprakash Narayan (Total Revolution), V.P. Singh (Anti-Corruption) and Anna Hazare (India Against Corruption). Without that, he argues, "a crowd just gathers for a cause and then dissipates".

The CVoter snap poll following the police action against the protesters indicates there is room for such a figure, but the CJP is not going down that route. As far as the most popular leader among the youth is concerned, Prime Minister Narendra Modi still leads with 39.8 per cent, while the Congress's Rahul Gandhi has 28 per cent support (as for the CJP, close to 50 per cent of the respondents said they would support them on other causes too). The BJP, though, had yet to learn that mere popular appeal is no cover against the wrath of the people. Says Deshmukh, "Our polling showed that 70 per cent of the people were demanding a resignation. That sentiment had built up nearly two months earlier.

INTERVIEW

'People have lost faith in all institutions'

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder ABHIJEET DIPKE talks at length with DHAVAL S. KULKARNI on the chances of launching a political party, the Centre's anti-cheating bill and the big takeaways from the Jantar Mantar protest. Excerpts:

Q. What are the CJP's plans for the future?

The issue of unemployment looms before us. The crowd at Jantar Mantar was not just made up of students, but also those from the 25- to 35-year age group. Many protesters had degrees, but lacked jobs.

Most people at Jantar Mantar were from Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Uttar Pradesh, as the youth there are dependent on the Public Services Commission (PSC) exams for social upliftment. These students are very frustrated. They asked us why we were speaking only about NEET and not the PSC exams. Complaints about irregularities in these exams and government recruitments have come from states across India. There is anger over the quality of education and its unaffordability too.

The CJP will also take up issues related to gig workers. A large number of Swiggy and Zomato workers turned up at the protest. The concept of gig working is good for western countries; in India, gig working is nothing but exploitation of labour. They need a safety net. We will also focus on complaints over E20 blended petrol. First, we will go to every state and district, hold public meetings and understand people's concerns and expectations from us. While interacting with the youth at Jantar Mantar, I realised that they are not taken seriously and are dismissed as a non-serious generation. They cannot be dismissed because their style of communication and lifestyle are different.

Q. Does the CJP have any political plans?

If the people want us to, we will have to consider it, but we have no such plans as of now. The CJP is a social movement. People have lost faith in all institutions. Public representatives change loyalties soon after being elected. The courts side with the ruling party and people are upset at the Enforcement Directorate (ED), Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and even the media. India needs a social movement in which people can rise above political affiliations. If we convert the CJP into a political outfit, they may unleash the ED or CBI on us.

"Our demand for compensation for the kin of suicide victims stands. We will agitate again if this is not met"

Q. What do you have to say about the charges that Left parties were spearheading the protest?

Student organisations across parties were involved—the National Students Union of India (NSUI), Association of Students for Alternative Politics (ASAP) of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and those from the Left. Leftist groups are being highlighted intentionally—all Opposition parties like the Congress, DMK, Trinamool Congress, Samajwadi Party, Shiv Sena (UBT), NCP and AAP supported us.